10 POINTS · SCORE YOURSELF IN 5 MINUTES

THE 10/10 PROFILE GUIDE

A scored audit of your LinkedIn profile for founders and B2B execs. Ten checks, one point each, with the rule, a template and a before and after for every one.

WHY BOTHER

Everyone you message checks your profile before they reply. The investor, the candidate, the buyer you cold DMed on Monday. They click your name, look for a few seconds, and decide if you're worth an answer.

Most founder profiles lose that moment. The headline says "Co-founder". The banner is LinkedIn's grey default or a city skyline. Nothing on the page says what the company does.

I'm a partner at RallyUp, where we write LinkedIn for B2B founders and executives. We've generated 21.3M+ impressions for the founders and execs we write for, and every one of those impressions sends some people to a profile. This is the audit we run on a profile before we post a word.

> **The honest limit.** These ten checks are my judgement from fixing founder profiles, not a LinkedIn ranking factor. A 10/10 profile won't get you reach on its own. It makes sure the people who do land on it know what you do, believe you, and know what to do next.

HOW TO SCORE

Open your profile in a private window so you see what a stranger sees. Go down the table. Give yourself 1 if you pass, 0 if you don't. No half points: if you have to argue for it, it's a 0.

#	ELEMENT	YOU PASS IF	SCORE
01	**Photo**	Bright, close, recent, clearly you	__ / 1
02	**Banner message**	Says who it's for and what you do, read in one glance	__ / 1
03	**Banner proof**	One piece of proof: a result, logos or a backer	__ / 1
04	**Banner call to action**	One clear next step	__ / 1
05	**Headline: who you help**	A stranger can say who you help and with what	__ / 1
06	**Headline: proof**	A number, a name or a backer, not an adjective	__ / 1
07	**About: opening lines**	The lines before "see more" say problem, fix and proof	__ / 1
08	**Featured section**	One to three items, the first one is what you want clicked	__ / 1

#	ELEMENT	YOU PASS IF	SCORE
09	**Experience**	Your current role shows results, not a job description	__ / 1
10	**How to work with you**	A stranger knows exactly what to do next	__ / 1

0 to 4: people are deciding not to reply. Do the 30 minute fix today. **5 to 7:** the basics are there, the proof isn't. **8 to 9:** fix the one or two misses this week. **10:** stop editing and go send the messages.

Every name, company and number in the examples below is made up.

THE 10 CHECKS

01 · PHOTO

A face people recognise when they meet you

FIX TIME: 4 MINUTES · WHERE: PROFILE PHOTO

Your photo shows up next to every message, comment and post. It's the first thing people see and the thing they check against your face on the call.

> **The rule.** Shoulders up, face filling most of the circle, in good light, taken in the last two years. Plain or soft background. You look like you on a good day, not like a passport.

> **Fails:** a dark photo, a photo cropped out of a group, sunglasses, a logo, a wedding, the grey silhouette, a picture from ten years ago.

HOW TO TAKE IT

Stand facing a window in daylight. Phone at eye level. Plain wall behind you. Take 20, pick the one where you look easiest to talk to.

BEFORE

Maya, co-founder of Tallyhouse: a dim photo from a conference, cropped from a group, her face a small part of the frame.

AFTER

Maya by a window, shoulders up, plain wall, smiling. Bright enough to recognise at thumbnail size.

02 · BANNER MESSAGE

Who it's for, in one glance

FIX TIME: 8 MINUTES, WITH THE NEXT TWO · WHERE: BACKGROUND PHOTO

The banner is the biggest space on your profile and most founders leave it grey. It's a free billboard above your name. Use it to say what you do and who for.

> **The rule.** One line, big enough to read on a phone. If someone has to read it twice, it has too much on it. Keep text away from the bottom left, where your photo sits. LinkedIn recommends 1584 × 396 pixels.

> **Fails:** LinkedIn's default grey banner, a stock photo, a skyline, a quote, or a banner so packed with logos, taglines and icons that you read it twice.

TEMPLATE

```
[Outcome] for [who].
e.g. "[Get paid faster] for [construction finance teams]."
```

BEFORE

A stock photo of a glass office tower with "Innovate. Disrupt. Grow." across it.

AFTER

"Supplier invoices matched in minutes, for construction finance teams."

03 · BANNER PROOF

One reason to believe you

WHERE: BACKGROUND PHOTO, UNDER THE MESSAGE

A claim with nothing behind it reads like an ad. One piece of proof turns it into a fact.

> **The rule.** Pick one: a client result, three to five customer logos, or borrowed trust, like the investors who backed you or the companies your team came from. One kind of proof, not all three.

> **Fails:** no proof at all, or a wall of fifteen logos nobody can read at thumbnail size.

PICK ONE

```
[Result] for [type of customer]
Trusted by [logo] [logo] [logo]
Backed by [investor] and [investor]
```

BEFORE

Nothing. Just the message.

AFTER

"Backed by Northgate Ventures" in small type under the message, with three customer logos.

04 · BANNER CALL TO ACTION

Tell them what to do next

WHERE: BACKGROUND PHOTO, RIGHT HAND SIDE

Someone who likes what they see needs somewhere to go. If you don't tell them, they go back to their feed.

> **The rule.** One action, written as an instruction, with a short address they can type. Join the waitlist. Book a demo. Read the newsletter. One, not three.

> **Fails:** no call to action, or three competing ones, or a long tracking link nobody will type.

TEMPLATE

```
[Verb] [the thing] at [short address]
e.g. "Join the waitlist at [company].com"
```

BEFORE

No next step anywhere on the banner.

AFTER

"Book a 15 minute demo at tallyhouse.com" on the right, away from the photo.

05 · HEADLINE: WHO YOU HELP

Not your title. What you do, and for who.

FIX TIME: 8 MINUTES, WITH THE NEXT ONE · WHERE: HEADLINE

Your headline follows you everywhere: under your name in comments, in search, in every DM preview. For most people it's the only line of your profile they read.

> **The rule.** Someone who has never heard of your company should be able to say who you help and with what, after reading it once.

> **Fails:** "Co-founder". "Co-founder, CEO, we're hiring". "Building something new". "Founder @ [company]" when nobody knows the company yet.

THREE FORMULAS

```
A. [Role] at [Company]: we help [who] [do what].
B. Helping [who] [outcome] | [Role], [Company]
C. [Company] = [what it is] for [who] | [Role]
```

BEFORE

Co-founder, CEO at Tallyhouse. We're hiring!

AFTER

CEO at Tallyhouse: we help construction finance teams match supplier invoices in minutes.

06 · HEADLINE: PROOF

A number beats an adjective

WHERE: END OF THE HEADLINE

"Passionate", "visionary" and "serial entrepreneur" are things anyone can type. A number, a name or a backer is something you have to have earned.

> **The rule.** Add one piece of proof to the end of the headline. It can be the same proof as the banner or a different one.

> **Fails:** no proof, or proof made of adjectives.

ADD ONE

```
| [Result] for [N] [customers]
| Backed by [investor]
| Ex-[company people know], [role]
```

BEFORE

Passionate sales leader | Visionary | Builder

AFTER

VP Sales at Kestrel Data: we help retailers forecast stock. | Built the first sales team at Fernway, 0 to 40 reps

07 · ABOUT: OPENING LINES

Write for the lines before "see more"

FIX TIME: 5 MINUTES · WHERE: ABOUT SECTION

Only the opening of your About shows before LinkedIn cuts it off. Most people never click "see more", so those first lines do the work.

> **The rule.** Open with the problem your buyer has, then what you do about it, then proof. Your life story goes further down, if anywhere.

> **Fails:** "I'm a passionate leader with 15 years of experience...". Starting with your childhood. A copy of your company's homepage.

TEMPLATE

```
[Who] [lose time or money on this problem].
At [Company], we [fix it by doing what].
[Proof: result, customers or backer].
[What to do next: where to find you].
```

BEFORE

I'm a results-driven founder passionate about the future of finance. With a background in...

AFTER

Construction finance teams spend days matching supplier invoices by hand. Tallyhouse does it in minutes. 60 firms use it every month. Book a demo at tallyhouse.com.

08 · FEATURED SECTION

Pick what they click first

FIX TIME: 3 MINUTES · WHERE: FEATURED

The Featured section sits near the top of your profile with pictures, which makes it the most clicked thing on the page after your name. Most founders leave it empty or full of old reposts.

> **The rule.** One to three items. The first is the thing you most want a stranger to see: a demo, a case study, the waitlist, your best post.

> **Fails:** empty, six items, or a repost of a funding announcement from two years ago.

ORDER

```
1. [The action you want: demo, waitlist, newsletter]
2. [Proof: a case study or customer story]
3. [Your best post, the one that explains what you do]
```

BEFORE

Empty.

AFTER

1. Two minute demo video. 2. A customer story. 3. Maya's post on why she started Tallyhouse.

09 · EXPERIENCE

Proof, not a job description

FIX TIME: THIS WEEK, NOT TODAY · WHERE: EXPERIENCE

Buyers and investors who scroll this far are checking if you've done it before. A list of duties tells them nothing. Results do.

> **The rule.** For your current role: one line on what the company does, then two or three results with a number in each. Older roles can be one line.

> **Fails:** "Responsible for managing...". Duties copied from a job ad. Your current role with no description at all.

TEMPLATE

```
[Company] [does what] for [who].
• [Result with a number]
• [Result with a number]
• [Who you work with or who backs you]
```

BEFORE

CEO. Responsible for strategy, fundraising and team leadership.

AFTER

Tallyhouse matches supplier invoices for construction finance teams. Grew from 0 to 60 customers in 18 months. Raised a seed round from Northgate Ventures.

10 · HOW TO WORK WITH YOU

Make the next step obvious

FIX TIME: 2 MINUTES · WHERE: END OF ABOUT, PLUS ONE OTHER PLACE

You did the hard part. They read your profile and they're interested. Don't make them work out how to buy, invest or apply.

> **The rule.** End your About with one clear next step, and repeat it in one other place: the banner, the first Featured item or your contact info. Same action everywhere.

> **Fails:** no next step, or "feel free to reach out", which asks the reader to do the thinking.

TEMPLATE

```
If you [are who you help] and [have the problem], [do this] at [address].
Or DM me "[keyword]" and I'll send you [the thing].
```

BEFORE

Feel free to reach out!

AFTER

If you run finance at a construction firm, book a 15 minute demo at tallyhouse.com.

FIX IT IN 30 MINUTES

Do it in this order. The top of the profile is seen by everyone, the bottom by a few. Fix what most people see first.

ORDER	FIX	TIME	CHECKS
1	**Headline.** Pick a formula, fill the brackets, add one proof point.	8 min	05, 06
2	**Banner.** One line, one proof, one action. A free design tool and a blank 1584 x 396 canvas is enough.	8 min	02, 03, 04
3	**About opening.** Problem, fix, proof, next step. Leave the rest for later.	5 min	07, 10
4	**Photo.** Window, eye level, plain wall. Retake it if it's dark.	4 min	01
5	**Featured.** Pin the one thing you want clicked first.	3 min	08
6	**Check the next step.** Same action in the About and one other place.	2 min	10
Later	**Experience.** Rewrite your current role as results this week.	20 min	09

The stranger test. When you're done, send your profile to one person outside your industry and ask two questions: what do I do, and who for? If they can't answer in one go, start again at the headline.

THE CHECKLIST

Print this page or keep it open next to your profile. Tick each one only when a stranger would agree.

- [ ] **01 Photo.** Bright, close, recent, plain background, clearly me.
- [ ] **02 Banner message.** One line that says what I do and who for. Readable on a phone in one glance.
- [ ] **03 Banner proof.** One kind of proof: a result, three to five logos, or a backer.
- [ ] **04 Banner call to action.** One action with a short address.
- [ ] **05 Headline: who I help.** A stranger can say who I help and with what.
- [ ] **06 Headline: proof.** A number, a name or a backer. No adjectives doing the work.
- [ ] **07 About opening.** Problem, fix, proof, all before "see more".
- [ ] **08 Featured.** One to three items, the first is the thing I want clicked.
- [ ] **09 Experience.** My current role shows what the company does and two or three results.
- [ ] **10 Next step.** The same clear action at the end of my About and in one other place.

My score	__ / 10

Then go back to the messages you sent last week that nobody answered. Now follow up.

Francisco Gost writes The Draft, a weekly letter on how top 1% startups crush organic marketing, at franciscogost.com

Partner at RallyUp. 21.3M+ impressions generated for B2B founders and execs.